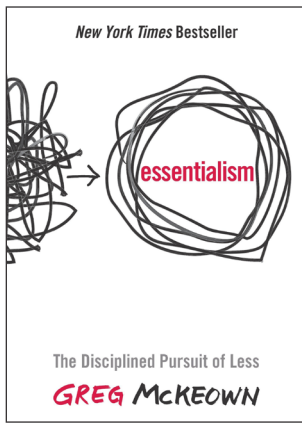




ESSENTIALISM

The Disciplined Pursuit of Less

GREG MCKEOWN

The Big “So What”

Often, we find ourselves feeling overworked, exhausted, perpetually busy yet unproductive. Essentialism is about focusing your energy only on what's essential, so you can do the right things that truly matter.

What is Essentialism?

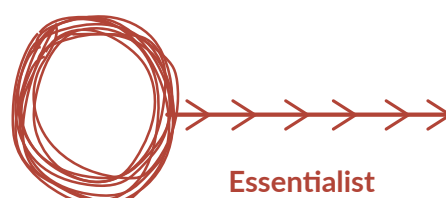
Essentialism is the discipline of continuously defining where we can create the most value, then finding ways to execute most effortlessly.

 Today, we have more choices than ever before. This, combined with increased connectivity, social pressure, and the myth that we can have it all, has led to the proliferation of nonessentialism. People find it hard to say “no” and are constantly stretched too thinly across too many areas.

 Both individuals and organizations also get caught in the Paradox of Success. They start out with a clarity of purpose which leads to success. As their success brings more options and opportunities, they start to get distracted, losing sight of their core priorities and key success factors. Their success thus ends up catalysing their failure.

 Essentialism is about designing and taking control of your life.

- The same amount of energy, when directed purposefully, can bring you much closer to your goal. This requires that you constantly step back to ask: “Am I investing in the right activities?” and “Is this the most important thing I should be doing now?”



KEY QUOTES

“The way of the Essentialist is the relentless pursuit of less but better...It means pursuing it in a disciplined way.”

“The preponderance of choice has overwhelmed our ability to manage it.”

“Success can distract us from focusing on the essential things that produce success in the first place.”

“Only once you give yourself permission to stop trying to do it all, to stop saying yes to everyone, can you make your highest contribution towards the things that really matter.”

“If you don’t prioritize your life, someone else will.”

- Know the right things you must do, reject everything else and direct your time and energy to create the biggest impact where it matters. In so doing, you drastically improve both your levels of performance and results.



The Essentialist Mindset

Essentialism involves 3 mindset shifts:



Choose. We can't always control the options presented to us, but we can *always* control the choices we make and how we spend our time and energy. Remove the words "I have to" which puts you in a reactive, helpless position. Use the words "I choose to"—remember that you can *always* choose how to respond to your circumstances.



Discern. We're surrounded by noise that confuses and distracts us. Stop thinking that everything is important. Learn to filter out the few vital things that are truly valuable from the mass of trivialities.



Trade-offs. Trade-offs are a fact of life. You can do *anything* but not *everything*.

- Southwest Airlines managed to achieve amazing growth in a notoriously unprofitable industry because it was deliberate about its trade-offs—it chose to keep costs down even if that meant alienating certain groups of people. On the other hand, Continental Airlines made the costly mistake of trying to straddle 2 vastly different strategies.
- Stop thinking "How can I do it all?" Instead, choose the problem you'd focus on, and ask "What trade-offs will I make?" and "How can I go really big on this?" See trade-offs not as losses but as opportunities to find the highest-impact options.

KEY QUOTES

"We often think of choice as a thing...a choice is an action. It is not just something we have but something we do."

"Distinguish the vital few from the trivial many."

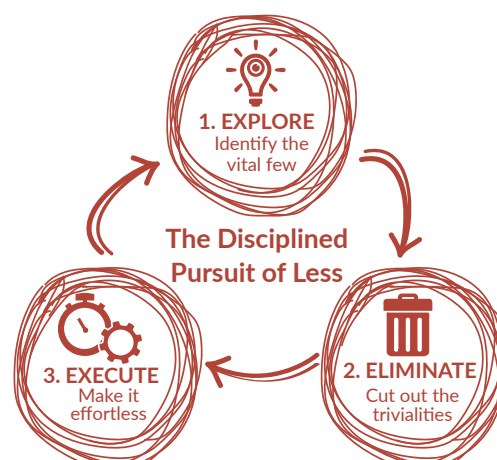
"We live in a world where almost everything is worthless and a very few things are exceptionally valuable."

"We can try to avoid the reality of trade-offs, but we can't escape them."

Becoming an Essentialist: the 3-Part Model



There are 3 key parts to Essentialism: explore, eliminate and execute. These elements work together in a self-reinforcing cycle.





Explore: Identify the Vital Few

Essentialists explore more options than non-Essentialists but don't react to most of them. **Create the space to think, listen, observe, play, rest and explore with the goal of identifying the activities/efforts that'll create the biggest contribution toward your goal.**



Escape. Today, people are typically too busy to think. It takes *deliberate effort* to create the time and space to escape, explore life, reflect on what's truly vital, and evaluate your options. Find the ideal spaces where you can concentrate and/or ideate. Set aside time regularly to read, expand your perspectives, explore new ideas and challenge your assumptions.



Look deeply. Great journalists go beyond factual reports; they dig deep to discover what's meaningful to people. Likewise, in all aspects of life, you gain true insights when you look below the surface to find the hidden truths and connect the parts to see the broader patterns.

- Train yourself to connect the dots and see the bigger picture or wider trend rather than react to every small event or trigger.
- To filter out the vital from the noise, learn to be a great observer and listener. Listen carefully to what's *not* being said. Pay attention to the essence that's being communicated; don't try to formulate your own response as you listen.
- Keep a journal where you note down daily thoughts and observations that you'd otherwise forget. Take an hour every 3 months to go through your journal entries and look for patterns that may surface.
- Always clarify the question or problem, i.e. "What question am I trying to answer?" or "What problem am I trying to solve?" Get out in the field to gather first-hand data or experience, and look for unusual or abnormal details.



Play (i.e. anything that you do for the joy of doing) is a vital source of brain stimulation and imagination.

- We're often most, creative, expressive and alive during play. Play opens up our minds to new options and possibilities, relieves stress (a barrier to creativity and productivity), and stimulates

KEY QUOTES

"To discern what is truly essential we need space to think, time to look and listen, permission to play, wisdom to sleep, and the discipline to apply highly selective criteria to the choices we make."

"In order to have focus, we need to escape to focus."

"The best journalists do not simply relay information. Their value is in discovering what really matters to people."

"In every set of facts, something essential is hidden."

"Listen for what others do not hear."

"Small, incremental changes are hard to see in the moment but over time can have a huge cumulative effect."

"Play doesn't just help us to explore what is essential. It is essential in and of itself."

both the logical and creative parts of the brain. That's why many breakthroughs—from Columbus' realization that the world was round to Newton's conceptualization of gravity—occurred during play.

- Indeed, many companies like Twitter, IDEO, Pixar and Google are already promoting fun and play at work. Consider what used to excite you as a child and find ways to recreate that today.



Sleep. You are your greatest asset—to create a massive contribution, you must first nurture a healthy mind, body and spirit. Sleep is a crucial investment to keep you operating at optimal levels. Pace yourself and recharge to ensure you don't burn out.

- Sleep has been found to improve creativity and problem-solving abilities. In deep sleep (even briefly), our brains make new connections that allow new ideas and solutions to emerge.
- Get 8-hours of sleep daily for peak performance. Anders Ericsson found that top violinists spent more time practicing than average violinists and slept more than the average American (for an average of 8.6 hours in every 24 hours). By regenerating themselves, they concentrated better and got more out of their practice.



Select. When an opportunity comes knocking, we tend to fear missing out if we say “no”. Yet, if you accept every opportunity, you'll be overwhelmed. Force yourself to be explicit about your decision-making criteria, then systematically select *only* what's the most ideal.

- Apply the 90 Percent Rule and say “yes” only to the top 10%. When you evaluate an option, focus on the 1 most important criterion to rate the option between 0-100. Reject all options that score <90%. You can also (i) list down 3 minimum criteria for an option to be considered and (ii) 3 extreme criteria for an option to be approved. Reject any option that doesn't fulfill both sets of criteria.
- Remember: you're looking for only the best options. Apply this to every aspect of your life, e.g. hiring *only* the ideal employees, attending *only* the most useful events and buying/keeping *only* what you absolutely love.

KEY QUOTES

“Play expands our minds in ways that allow us to explore: to germinate new ideas or see old ideas in a new light.”

“The best asset we have for making a contribution to the world is ourselves.”

“Sleep will enhance your ability to explore, make connections, and do less but better throughout your waking hours.”

“Sometimes you will have to turn down a seemingly very good option and have faith that the perfect option will soon come along.”

“If it isn't a clear yes, then it's a clear no.”

“We aren't looking for a plethora of good things to do. We are looking for the one where we can make our absolutely highest point of contribution.”



Eliminate: Cut Out the Trivialities

After you've distinguished the vital few from the trivial majority, you must cut off the latter from your life.



Clarify. To eliminate activities that aren't aligned with your goal/purpose, you must first know what your goal/purpose is.

- In organizations, teams that lack clarity tend to be rife with politics; people create their own games/rules and pursue conflicting interests. In our personal lives, people that lack clarity get distracted by diverse priorities and get lost in trivialities like how many "likes" they have on social media.
- Define your "essential intent" to stay clear and focused on what matters. This is a strategic decision that'll eliminate thousands of other decisions in the years to come, and must be both concrete and inspirational, e.g. "to get everyone in South Africa online by end of 2020". To gain clarity, ask good questions like "What's the 1 thing we must be truly outstanding in?" or "How will we know that we've succeeded?"



Dare. It takes courage to say "no"—to act against social pressures and overcome our fears of missing out or disappointing others.

- Each time you say "yes" to something nonessential, you're saying "no" to something essential. Focus on the trade-offs so it's easier to reject the nonessentials.
- Humans are social creatures and we intuitively want to be accepted by others. We feel bad about rejecting or disappointing others. Saying "no" could reduce your popularity in the short term, but it earns you respect in the long term. In fact, a clear and polite "no" is much better than a non-committal "yes" that you fail to deliver on.
- Learn to say "no" firmly but skillfully:
 - (i) Separate the decision from the relationship—remember that you're rejecting the request, not the person.
 - (ii) Reject a request gracefully. Pause for 3 seconds, then respond with something like, "I'd love to help you on the project but I

KEY QUOTES

"When there is a serious lack of clarity about what the team stands for and what their goals and roles are, people experience confusion, stress, and frustration."

"Once the big decision is made, all subsequent decisions come into better focus."

"Clarity about what is essential fuels us with the strength to say no to the nonessentials."

"Part of living the way of the Essentialist is realizing respect is far more valuable than popularity in the long run."

"As hard as it can be to say no to someone, failing to do so can cause us to miss out on something far more important."

don't have the bandwidth at the moment." If you need time to consider, simply say, "Let me check my availability and get back to you." You can also use email auto-responders to explain why you're currently unavailable. If your boss asks you to do something on top of existing priorities, seek clarification e.g. "I'd be happy to prioritize this. Which of these other projects should I set aside to focus on this project?" You can also offer other viable alternatives to the requester.



Uncommit. We tend to continue something just because we've always done it or because of what we'd already invested/sunk in it.

- When you pour more time, energy or money into a bad choice or unessential activity, you're wasting even more resources. Cut your losses and refocus your current/future resources on what's useful and essential.
- To overcome the sunk cost bias, ask yourself questions like: "If I don't already own this, how much would I pay for it?", "If I don't already do this, will I start doing it?" or "If I didn't have this opportunity, what would I be willing to do to acquire it?" You can also get an objective opinion from a neutral third party who's not emotionally invested in the situation.
- Don't stick blindly to status quo; start your plans from scratch each time to evaluate every item against your criteria.
- When you're presented with an opportunity or request, pause for 5 seconds to ask yourself if it's essential before you respond. If you're unsure whether something is essential, simply remove it to test if there's any real impact.



Edit. Be like an editor—relentlessly remove what's irrelevant, unimportant or doesn't add to the masterpiece.

- By removing the nonessential, a great editor adds value to a movie's plot and characters, making them more coherent and impactful. Likewise, disciplined editing helps to cut away things in your life that are confusing, distracting, disruptive or simply aren't aligned with your goals.

KEY QUOTES

"It's natural not to want to let go of what we wasted on a bad choice, but when we don't, we doom ourselves to keep wasting even more."

"Every use of time, energy, or resources has to justify itself anew. If it no longer fits, eliminate it altogether."

"A good film editor... eliminates everything but the elements that absolutely need to be there."

- Condense your existing activities and communications to make them as clear and concise as possible, e.g. communicate in fewer words or run a meeting in less time.
- Editing also helps to improve the accuracy or effectiveness of your efforts, so they contribute most directly to your goals.



Limit. Technology has significantly blurred the lines between work and family, with employees often being expected to respond to emails and messages after work-hours or on weekends. We may also encounter people who encroach into our personal space, offload their problems on us, or try to exploit us for their own gains. To protect what's essential, you must set boundaries. It's vital to know your boundaries and stand firm on them—once you start to make exceptions, you're likely to keep making more and more exceptions until you're living on others' terms. When you take on others' problems, you dilute your focus while disempowering others from taking control of their lives.

- It's vital to know your boundaries and stand firm on them—once you start to make exceptions, you're likely to keep making more and more exceptions until you're living on others' terms. When you take on others' problems, you dilute your focus while disempowering others from taking control of their lives.
- Such boundaries do not constrain you; they free you to select your playing field and focus on winning the game that matters.
- In some cases, setting your boundaries will involve trade-offs, e.g. it may limit your career progress in certain companies. However, the cost of not setting your boundaries is even higher as you may end up hurting what's most essential to you.
- Define your deal-breakers. Think of someone who frequently distracts you from your priorities and list down the types of requests you should reject in future. Each time you feel obliged to do something you'd rather not, make a note of why you feel violated. Review your notes to find your hidden boundaries.
- When you're working with people with different priorities or approaches, it helps to craft a social contract to establish mutual boundaries to reduce friction.

KEY QUOTES

"A good editor is someone who uses deliberate subtraction to actually add life to the ideas, setting, plot, and characters."

"When we don't set clear boundaries in our lives we can end up imprisoned by the limits others have set for us."

"Boundaries are a little like the walls of a sandcastle. The second we let one fall over, the rest of them come crashing down."

"Not pushing back costs more: our ability to choose what is most essential in life."



Execute: Remove Constraints & Make Execution Effortless

Non-Essentialists spend their time/effort trying to force their way through execution, while Essentialists invest time/effort to figure out how to do things in the least effortful way.



Buffer. We can't predict what will happen in the future. We can only expect the unexpected and build in a buffer, i.e. something that prevents 2 things from clashing and causing damage.

- Don't assume the best then find yourself stuck with inadequate time/resources. Plan ahead and create buffers for contingencies, e.g. add 50% buffer for travelling time.
- When planning for an important project, ask several key questions: (i) What risks do I face? (ii) What's the worst-case scenario and the social/financial impact? and (iii) What can I do to reduce these risks or improve my resilience to them?



Subtract. Adding resources won't necessarily increase your output. You must address the constraints that are slowing you down.

- Don't randomly act on the most visible or immediate obstacles. Step back, examine the whole system to identify the biggest bottlenecks and tackle those instead.
- Return to the earlier question: "How will we know that we've succeeded?" Ensure you have a clear, concrete essential intent, then (i) identify the constraints that are slowing you down and (ii) start by removing the biggest obstacles that, once removed, would eliminate most of the other obstacles.



Progress. To get massive results, you don't need flashy ideas. Neither must you achieve everything at once. Identify the priorities with the biggest contributions, take baby steps and celebrate each small win until you get to your big goal.

- Invest some time to set up a system that allows you to execute as smoothly and effortlessly as possible. The Richmond Police Department decided to take an unusual approach to recidivism. Rather than target people who'd already committed crimes,

KEY QUOTES

"Instead of focusing on the efforts and resources we need to add, the Essentialist focuses on the constraints or obstacles we need to remove."

"Removing obstacles... (is) kind of like dislodging a boulder at the top of a hill. All it takes is a small shove, then momentum will naturally build."

"Once a small amount of initial effort was invested to set up the system, it worked without friction."

they started to focus on the cause of the crimes and issue tickets for people who demonstrated desired behaviors. This shift in approach reduced recidivism from 60% to 8% over a decade.

- Businesses often create a minimal viable product—the simplest form of a product to deliver the intended value to target customers. Likewise, you can consider the “minimum viable progress” that’ll be valuable to your essential task at hand.
- Don’t wait till the last minute to tackle your projects. You can achieve superior results by starting early with the minimum viable preparation. Ask yourself: “What’s the minimum I could do now to prepare?”. For example, if you’re delivering a speech in 6 months, you can start researching your topic now.
- Make your progress visible and celebrate small wins to keep yourself motivated.



Flow. There’s extensive research to show that routine can make something difficult seem relatively easy.

- When you learn or do something new, it’s always more effortful initially. As you do the same thing repeatedly over a period of time, it becomes a habit that you perform without conscious thought, e.g. driving or brushing your teeth.
- Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi found that the most creative people have routines that help them to perform at their best. The routines create a natural rhythm and free their minds to concentrate fully on their tasks. By investing some effort initially to establish a helpful routine, you can reduce the struggle of taking consistent action. For years, serial Olympic gold medallist Michael Phelps followed the same routine—from his preparation and training in the mornings to his visualization just before he went to bed. His achievements may have seemed effortless, but in reality they came from years of routine practice and conditioning.
- On the other hand, once bad habits/routines are formed, it can be extremely hard to change them. To change an existing habit, you need to first identify the cue that triggers the behavior (e.g. what triggers you to reach for some chocolates?). Then,

KEY QUOTES

“The Essentialist designs a routine that makes achieving what you have identified as essential to the default position.”

each time the cue surfaces, make a deliberate effort to change your behavior (e.g. grab a salad instead). Over time, you'll create new neural connections in your brain to forge new habits. You can also create new triggers, such as doing something at the same time and place daily until it becomes second nature to you.

- Develop a routine to tackle the hardest tasks first. To keep things fresh, you can also consider having different routines for different days of the week.



Focus. To operate at your peak, you must deliberately focus on what's the most crucial, right now.

- Don't waste energy fretting about past mistakes or future problems. Shift your attention to how you can make the most of the present moment. Constantly ask yourself this question throughout the day, week, month and year: "What's the most important *now*?" This keeps you focused on (i) the present moment, (ii) your own game and (iii) what's most vital.
- We can multi-task (i.e. do more than 1 thing at a time such as washing the dishes while watching TV) but we can't multi-focus (i.e. focus on more than 1 thing at a time). Focus singularly on your most important tasks. When you're calm and present, you'll also concentrate better, think more clearly and enjoy your task more.
- Whenever you feel overwhelmed, pause and take a deep breath. Recenter yourself and ask what's the most important *right now* (not what's important 1 hour or 1 day later). Drop all other items temporarily and focus only on that 1 priority.



Be. Don't add Essentialism on top of everything else in your life. Make it a fundamental part of who you are and how you live.

- Essentialism isn't something that you do, but something that you become. It's about thinking, acting and living in a way that allows you to have the greatest possible contribution and fulfillment, so you live a meaningful life without regret. Gautama Buddha left his life as prince to embrace asceticism, eventually attaining enlightenment and founding Buddhism. Mohandas Gandhi gave up his wealth to pursue a simple life dedicated to liberating the oppressed. What will *your* biggest contribution be?

KEY QUOTES

"Every second spent worrying about a past or future moment distracts us from what is important in the here and now."

"Multi-tasking itself is not the enemy of Essentialism; pretending we can 'multifocus' is."

"We can all live a life not just of simplicity but of high contribution and meaning."

- As Essentialism becomes an integral part of who you are, you'll become more astute about what you put on your to-do list (rather than trying to finish more and more tasks). You'll find it more effortless to achieve results as you remove constraints and install systems to reduce friction. And, with greater clarity, purpose and presence, you'll find much more joy in life and living.

KEY QUOTES

"If you allow yourself to fully embrace Essentialism—to really live it, in everything you do, whether at home or at work—it can become a part of the way you see and understand the world."